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Sincaraz, shorthand for the new Big Two — Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner — have combined to capture the last eight Major titles (two apiece during 2024 and 2025) and rapidly pulled ahead of the so-called contenders on the ATP Tour. **This marks the longest such streak since Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal compiled 11 straight Major titles from 2005-2007.** The legendary Big Three seem like a distant memory now, as does Novak Djokovic's domination in 2023 when he won three Majors.

Some among the tennis cognoscenti, such as *ESPN* analyst Patrick McEnroe, recognised the extraordinary talents of Sincaraz when they first traded explosive shots at the 2021 Paris Masters, with Alcaraz prevailing 7-6 (1), 7-5. "They literally changed the game," said Patrick, John McEnroe's younger brother. "They've separated themselves even more from the rest [in the last two years]. Even Djokovic conceded he can't beat these guys. The only guy who can beat them is the other guy on the other side of the net when they play [each other]."

Sam Querrey, a former No. 11 and now an *ESPN* analyst, said, "It seems like the days of playing defence are gone" — because of the otherworldly offences of Sincaraz. The hyper-athletic Spaniard can hit every shot in the book and then some he's invented. He boasts the best net game in tennis history because of his impeccable volleying and half-volleying technique, plus dazzling speed, agility, reflexes, balance, and touch. Against Sinner's ferocious groundstrokes, he won 74 per cent of net points (20 of 27). His vast array of serves with varying amounts of spin and power makes him one of the top servers today. **Against Sinner, considered the best serve returner along with Djokovic, Carlitos belted 10 aces with no double faults, won 83 per cent of his first-serve points (45 of 54), and lost his serve just once.** His versatile and high-octane forehand ranks among the most lethal in any era. And as John McEnroe, the 1980s superstar, said, "Has anyone ever seen a faster player?"

Alcaraz's 6-1, 3-6, 6-3, 6-4 U.S. Open triumph doesn't rank as one of the greatest matches of all time like his epic 4-6, 6-7(4), 6-4, 7-6(3), 7-6(2) French Open final against Sinner. Nor does it match the Italian's 4-6, 6-4, 6-4, 6-4 high-calibre Wimbledon final victory, where Sinner's

relentless aggression and improved net skills — winning 30 of 40 points (75 per cent) — didn't allow Alcaraz to play his all-court game effectively.

The 15th edition of the Sincaraz rivalry will be remembered as a showcase for the genius of Alcaraz. "Today, I was just brilliant, to be honest. If I want to beat Jannik on the biggest stage, I have to be brilliant, which I'm really happy about," crowed the normally modest Spaniard.

President Donald Trump, a former recreational player and long-time tennis fan, attended the final along with celebrities Bruce Springsteen, Ben Stiller, and Christine Taylor, plus star athletes Steph Curry, Lindsey Vonn, and Sergio Garcia (Alcaraz's golf buddy), and tennis legends Bjorn Borg, Jimmy Connors, and Ivan Lendl, who presented the winner's trophy to Alcaraz.

The 2 p.m. starting time was pushed back to 2.45 p.m. due to additional security measures for Trump, to allow the more than 23,000 spectators to reach their seats. While the fans were slow to file in, Alcaraz got off to a fast start, converting his third break point for a quick 1-0 lead.

The 22-year-old Spaniard, clad in purple shorts and shoes and a plum sleeveless shirt that flaunted his muscular physique, broke again for a 5-2 lead and held serve at love to take the opening set 6-2.

In the second set, Sinner got some help from an unexpected source: Alcaraz himself. Throughout the tournament, Carlitos found the right balance between controlled aggression and entertaining shot-making, seldom getting reckless or toying with his opponents. Whether from overconfidence or lack of concentration, he lost the plot with Sinner serving at 1-all, love-15 in the second set. Alcaraz had just struck a backhand volley winner, causing Sinner to shake his head in frustration. Alcaraz then, strangely, started playing around, as he occasionally does, hitting soft slices that Sinner pummeled. "If I were Alcaraz, I'd keep going big to keep Sinner rattled," advised the elder

THE GULF BETWEEN SINCARAZ AND THE REST OF THE FIELD IS LARGE AND GROWING SIGNIFICANTLY